The BRICS and G20 Summits are spotlighting youth innovation and entrepreneurship in the Global South. How does iAccelerate fit into that global conversation?

It aligns perfectly. I'm optimistic because I see South African youth as key problem-solvers not just for our country, but for the continent and beyond. They're smart, driven, and ready to lead change; they just need the right tools. The fact that BRICS+ and G20 are prioritising youth entrepreneurship validates our mission. I'd love to see youth given a formal platform at these summits. A space not just to be celebrated, but to contribute meaningfully. Imagine BRICS nations connecting young entrepreneurs with investors and mentors across borders.



What lessons can countries in the Global South learn from one another about empowering young entrepreneurs?

There's so much we can learn. In India, for example, entrepreneurship education is being implemented at a massive scale, reaching millions. In Vietnam, programmes focus on smaller, more personal engagement. Both models work, and both offer valuable lessons.

The key is collaboration, not competition. Countries in the Global South should share experiences and best practices openly. By learning from one another, we can build more effective programmes that uplift young people across regions.

How can cross-border collaboration strengthen local innovation ecosystems?

On a youth level, collaboration should start with cultural and entrepreneurial exchanges. Imagine South African students working with peers from Brazil or India to solve shared problems. The challenges are similar, and so are the solutions. These exchanges encourage open dialogue, creativity, and mutual learning.

At a higher level, governments and businesses must work together. Policy frameworks, trade agreements, and private-sector innovation all play a role. Take the example of Brazil's neobanks; they've thrived there, and South Africa has the ecosystem to host similar ventures. Collaboration between governments and businesses could make that possible, driving innovation across borders.

What role can academia play in nurturing youth innovation?

Academic exchange is just as vital for students, faculty, and institutions. Entrepreneurship shouldn't sit apart from traditional disciplines. We need to integrate it into law, engineering, and science, so students in any field learn to think entrepreneurially.

I've seen inspiring examples in China and India, where universities link STEM and business departments to help technical students develop entrepreneurial mindsets. This approach speeds up innovation and turns research into viable solutions. For BRICS and the Global South, such partnerships could happen not only within universities but across continents.

What's next for iAccelerate South Africa?

For now, we're focused on getting it right in Cape Town, building strong foundations with smaller cohorts. Then we plan to expand to Johannesburg, Durban, and eventually into Sub-Saharan Africa. We also want to grow beyond high schools, creating programmes for university students and young professionals. Partnerships will be key. As the African proverb says, "If you want to go fast, go alone. If you want to go far, go together." Collaboration will drive our next chapter, linking education, investment, and entrepreneurship into one sustainable ecosystem.

What message would you share with young people across the Global South who want to make a difference but don't know where to start?

Start with the problem, not the solution. Find something in your community that needs fixing and gather people who care about it, too. Once you begin moving, momentum builds, possibilities open up. The hardest part is taking the first step, but that's where change begins.

And finally, what would you like world leaders at the G20 Summit to understand about Africa's youth?

Africa's youth are the future. We have the largest youth population in the world, an unstoppable force for innovation and growth. Whether they're leading from within the continent or abroad, young Africans will shape the next era. World leaders need to recognise that working with Africa's youth is not optional; it's essential. The future is African, and it's already unfolding.